

Thales also used geometric principles to determine the distance of a ship from the shore. One of his most impressive yet controversial feats, as alleged by Herodotus, was to have correctly predicted a total solar eclipse, which took place on March 28, 585 BCE. This prediction would have required Thales to identify an 18-year cycle in the movements of the Sun and the Moon (the Saros cycle), which many believe casts doubt on Herodotus's claim.

Legacy

The first person in Western society recorded as having engaged in rational and scientific thought, Thales inspired others to follow his approach through his questioning mind and his application of deductive reasoning. He initiated a new wave of thinking; his teachings sparked debate and counter-theorems, and form the origin of modern scientific thought.

Applying observation
and reason to questions
about the natural world,
Thales overturned centuries
of traditional views and
laid the foundations of
empirical science.

PYTHAGORAS

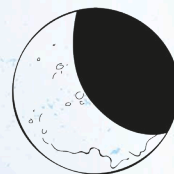
The renowned ancient Greek Pythagoras was a mathematician and philosopher.



Inspired by Thales, Pythagoras (c.570–500 BCE) believed that the world is mathematical in nature. Aged 30, he set up a commune that pursued mathematical research and mysticism. While his work is known only through his disciples, he made key contributions to Western thought, including the idea that the Earth and the planets orbit around a central "Hearth." He had a profound influence on both Plato and Aristotle.

CREDITED WITH
DISCOVERING
5 GEOMETRIC
THEOREMS

CORRECTLY
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15-
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CONSIDERED
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